

Department of Economics
Johns Hopkins University
Baltimore, MD 21218
dedwar65@jh.edu

December 21, 2025

Search Committee
Department of Economics
State University of New York at Cortland
Cortland, NY

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for the tenure-track Assistant Professor position in the Economics Department at the State University of New York at Cortland. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at Johns Hopkins University, advised by Professors Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis, and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My research fields are macroeconomics, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on understanding the determinants of wealth inequality and the mechanisms through which heterogeneity in returns to wealth shapes aggregate outcomes. In my job-market paper, I estimate the degree of heterogeneity in individual portfolio returns using micro-data from the Survey of Consumer Finances and simulate a structural model in which households face idiosyncratic return risk. I show that allowing for persistent heterogeneity in returns substantially improves the model's ability to match the empirical distribution of wealth, offering a tractable way to connect micro-level return dispersion to macroeconomic inequality.

In a second project, I use the Health and Retirement Study to examine the relationship between interpersonal trust and portfolio performance. Building on the literature that finds a hump-shaped relationship between trust and income, I show that a similar relationship holds for individual returns to wealth measured in the HRS data, highlighting a behavioral channel through which social attitudes shape saving and investment outcomes. This work also provides new estimates of the persistent component of returns to net worth, which motivate the calibration of heterogeneity in my structural model.

SUNY Cortland is a strong fit for my interests as a teacher and scholar. The department's emphasis on undergraduate education, applied learning, and interdisciplinary programs in Business Economics, Political Economy, and Entrepreneurship closely aligns with my training and experience. I am particularly attracted to Cortland's pluralist orientation and its commitment to fostering an equitable and inclusive learning environment for a diverse student body.

Teaching. I have experience teaching and supporting undergraduate courses in *Principles of Macroeconomics*, *Intermediate Macroeconomics*, and applied quantitative courses. My teaching approach emphasizes economic intuition, real-world applications, and clear connections between theory, data, and decision making. At SUNY Cortland, I would be well prepared to teach principles courses that support programs in Business Economics and Management, including introductory management, marketing, and entrepreneurship, as well as upper-level electives that draw on my research interests in economic behavior, inequality, and applied policy analysis. I place a strong

emphasis on student advising, mentoring, and accessibility, and I value close interaction with undergraduates as a core part of effective teaching.

I am enthusiastic about the opportunity to contribute to SUNY Cortland's growing Economics Department and to support its mission of providing accessible, high-quality public education. I would welcome the opportunity to build a long-term academic career at Cortland through teaching, research, and service that supports student success and departmental growth.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would be happy to provide any additional information and would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application further.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards